AMERICAN POLITICAL INSTITUTIONS:
STATE POLITICS AND POLICYMAKING

PLSC 541
M 1:30PM – 4:30PM
Sparks 006

Michael Nelson
mjn15@psu.edu
Office: SWLAB 407
Office Hours: M 12-1
(Better by Appointment)

COURSE DESCRIPTION

The fifty state governments are often described as "laboratories of democracy." In this course, we examine that idea from two perspectives. First, the phrase refers to the role states play in the policymaking process by experimenting with policies across time and place. We will study how policies are developed and implemented in the states, how innovations spread across state lines, and how the federal government encourages—or discourages—policy experimentation. Second, the states also serve as laboratories for scholars. Because they share many institutional similarities while varying in important political and social characteristics, the states provide valuable opportunities to study political institutions, mass behavior, policymaking, and representation. As we review the literature on state politics and policymaking, we will consider how scholars use variation across the states to investigate broader questions about American politics. Students in this course are expected to complete the assigned readings, to contribute meaningfully to class discussions, and to complete a variety of formal and informal writing assignments.

COURSE GOALS

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

(1) Explain the major findings in the study of American state political behavior, institutions, and policymaking.
(2) Explain data analytic and methodological tools used by scholars of state politics.
(3) Evaluate studies of American state politics orally and in writing.
(4) Communicate results of original research orally and in writing.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

- Summarize core findings from the state politics literatures on political behavior, political institutions, and policymaking.
- Explain how cross-state variation can be used to test general political science theories.
- Apply theoretical frameworks from the literature to new empirical contexts.
- Interpret empirical results (e.g., tables and figures) from published studies.
- Critically assess the research design and evidence in scholarly articles.
- Formulate a clear, tractable question related to state politics.
- Develop a feasible research design to test that research question.

COURSE MATERIALS

We will read a variety of books and articles. Two are particularly worthy of purchase. The articles are available online. If you have trouble finding copies of any assigned reading, please let me know.

- Key, V.O. 1949. *Southern Politics in State and Nation*. New York: Alfred A. Knopf.
- Erikson, Robert, Gerald Wright, and John McIver. 1993. *Statehouse Democracy: Public Opinion and Policy in the American States*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

The requirements for this course involve both (1) the completion of reading assignments and written work on your own outside of our class meetings and (2) your active and informed contributions to our course discussions when we meet. This course is a seminar. You are expected to come prepared to talk.

ARTICLE REVIEW (15%): As a midterm "exam," I will e-mail you a blinded unpublished manuscript on a topic relating to state politics and policy. You may not discuss the manuscript with your peers but may use external (e.g. internet) resources for additional information as needed as you craft a 2-3 page (single-spaced) review of the article appropriate for *State Politics and Policy Quarterly*.

RESPONSE PAPERS (15%). Three times during the semester (weeks 1-5, 6-10, and 11-15), you should select one core article of your choice from the required reading list for that week and write a 5-7-page (double-spaced) response to the paper. Your response should *not* summarize the article. Instead, you should (a) state the paper's research question and its stated contribution to the literature (~1 page), (b) critique constructively the paper's argument and/or analysis (2-3 pages), and (c) describe a follow-up paper, of the sort that could be plausibly be completed with the time/resources available to a graduate student working on a M.A. thesis or dissertation chapter (e.g., limited time and financial resources) that would advance the research (2-3 pages).

Some notes on how to be successful in a paper like this:

- Jump right in. No need for a florid introduction. I've read the paper. Just start in the first sentence of the paper by stating the paper's research question and move immediately into analyzing the paper's contribution: how does it "fit" in the existing literature?
- 2-3 major critiques about the paper are better than many "smaller" critiques.
- Ideally one or more of your critiques should lead into your proposed follow-up paper.
- You are welcome to cite other articles in your response but you are not obligated to do so.
- **I am very strict about deadlines on this paper.** They must be submitted on Canvas by noon the day before class. If they are late, they will not count. If you don't turn in a paper by the end of the unit, you will not be able to make it up. Plan ahead.

RESEARCH PROJECT (50% Total). This course culminates with the production of an original research project. You may choose any topic in state politics or comparative democratic institutions that interests you, though my hope is that this project will help you start to think about the sort of research projects that will interest you as you progress through graduate school. To help you finish the project on schedule, you will complete it in stages. You may choose to complete: (a) a research design, (b) a research paper, or (c) a reanalysis.

A. Research Paper. A research paper moves beyond a design by providing a test of a theoretical argument. A strong manuscript would have all the core components of a paper that could form the basis of a MA thesis, conference paper, or dissertation chapter. I highly encourage 2nd and 3rd year Ph.D. students to take this option.
B. Research Design. A research design is a well-thought-out plan that "sells" your research question as an essential one, explains why that original question is motivated by the extant research, clearly explains the testable, falsifiable hypotheses you hope to examine, and explains the data with which you plan to test those hypotheses, including both the data collection and analysis stages of the process. Basically, you should think about this as a highly detailed overview of a research project that likely lacks the empirical analysis that would enable one to actually test the proposed theory (though some preliminary data analysis, if available, may be useful as proof of concept). This option is only available to first year students, undergraduate students, and MPP students.

C. Renanalysis Paper. A reanalysis paper *replicates* and *reanalyzes* an existing published finding. Your research paper should *not* simply reproduce the table of results and figures included in the article you select. You will conduct a thorough *reanalysis* of the paper by embracing the authors' theory and hypotheses but writing your own code to analyze the data and fit the model(s) presented in the article. Be careful! Anyone can find "reasonable" ways of changing someone else's models so that coefficient estimates change. That is not the objective of this assignment. The goal of this research paper is for you to grasp the complete research process by focusing on characteristics of the data, the most appropriate quantitative method for establishing a clear connection between theory and empirics, hypothesis testing, and the substantive interpretation and visualization of the results.

Regardless of your assignment choice, you will complete the following assignments. I will include my assessment of your checkpoints (including their quality and timeliness) and your in class presentations in my evaluation of your final manuscript.

- Checkpoint #1: Research Proposal Meeting. You must meet with me by October 2 to receive approval for your project. At least 24 hours before the meeting, please upload to Canvas a 2-page document that outlines 2-3 proposed topics. During this meeting, we will discuss proposed topics and which assignment is the best fit for your stage in the program, substantive interests, and career goals. For those students interested in a Renanalysis Paper, indicate whether you have obtained the author's original data.

- Checkpoint #2: Literature Review. The purpose of the literature review is to bring your reader up to speed about the current state of knowledge on a topic and, in the process, explain why there has not been a good answer to your research question. A good literature review is *not* a summary of a bunch of articles. Instead, it weaves the articles together to describe the state of knowledge on that topic. *A literature review is an argument about what "we" know and do not know about your topic. It is an argument that your paper deserves to be written.* In a paper of about 6 pages (double-spaced) in length, you should do three things: (1) Summarize the literature/existing explanations in terms of method and major findings. (2) Critique the strengths and weaknesses of each literature/explanation. (3) Identify why there is a need in the literature for your proposed research.

  To help you prepare to write this paper, take careful notes. Pay attention to how articles "speak" to each other: which articles agree? Which articles disagree? Once you've found the points of consensus and dissensus in the literature, you can begin writing. *The topic sentences in your literature review should be* ***your*** *summary of the literature, and the supporting sentences in each paragraph should use the articles as sources.* You should plan to read at least 10 articles (the more the better!) on your topic before you start writing. You may not cite all of those sources in the eventual literature review, but you need to read enough before you write so that you know the state of the literature on the topic.

- Checkpoint #3: Data Report. Each student will write a report on data that they would (or will) use to test their theory. The report should be 3-5 pages long and discuss the availability of data, how key concepts in the theory would be measured, and the reliability and validity of those measurements (or how reliability and validity would be assessed). For those students writing a research paper or a reanalysis paper, your Data Report should contain some data analysis.

- Checkpoint #4: Peer Review. You will circulate a draft of your paper to two of your colleagues (selected by me). You will read and comment on the drafts of the two colleagues and provide them with constructive critiques of their argument, research design, and (if applicable) data analysis. You may comment on mechanical (grammatical) errors, but those should not be the focus of your commentary. You will summarize your comments in a memorandum (about 2 double-spaced pages) that you will submit to Prof. Nelson.

- Final Paper and Response Memo. Submit your final, revised manuscript—along with a memo responding to your classmates' critiques—on Canvas. Most completed manuscripts will be about 25 double-spaced pages (though concision is always welcomed).

- In-Class Presentations: We will spend the last hour of most class sessions workshopping your papers. Each week, I will assign the students who will present the following week. Students should expect to present about three times over the course of the semester.

PARTICIPATION (20%). This is a graduate seminar. It is your collective job to carry most of our class discussion. The final portion of your grade is based on your ability and willingness to contribute to our class. Everyone's experience in this course is enhanced by regular attendance and active participation; conversely, everyone's experience suffers if individuals do not participate. Remember that a sincere question often adds as much (if not more) to our understanding of the course material as an explanation of the week's readings. So, don't be afraid to speak up!

Please remember that attending class and sitting silently is not, by definition, "participation." Also, please note that I do not penalize you directly for missing class (though multiple absences will adversely affect your grade through a lower participation score).

You will also grade your own participation. After every 5-week period (so three times throughout the semester), I will ask you to reflect on your participation in the course. Based on your reflection and your contribution to the course, I will grade your participation. In this way, I hope to make you assess critically your contribution to the seminar and also to provide you with regular feedback on your performance.

EXPECTATIONS/PROCEDURES

RESPECT. In this course, we are all engaged in the endeavor of building a stronger understanding of American politics. Everyone comes to this course with a different background in the subject (particularly with respect to the technical aspects of the readings). It is important that we all treat each other with the utmost respect.

CRITICISM. This is a seminar and, as such, it is our job to be critics. As you read for class, you should examine the goals of an article, the persuasiveness of the evidence it presents in support of its theory, and the place it makes for itself in the literature. Remember that a harsh critique isn't the same thing as an intellectually rigorous one, and focus less on what you perceive to be flaws and more on what you could learn from the article. Oftentimes, it is more difficult to point out what is "good" than what is "bad". In other words, treat our authors the way you would like to be treated by students in your shoes in 20 years.

OFFICE HOURS. I have office hours, listed at the beginning of the syllabus. My door is usually open, and you shouldn't hesitate to stop by outside of my scheduled office hour times.

LATE ASSIGNMENTS. Assignments not submitted by the assigned due date and time are late and will be penalized by a 5% per day deduction. This is a graduate class, so I expect you to communicate with me about things that affect your ability to get an assignment in on time. All assignments must be completed to complete this course.

EXTENSIONS. Extensions will be granted in only the most severe circumstances. If you foresee the need for an extension, one needs to be requested and granted at least 24 hours before the due date. No one is entitled to an extension; they will be offered only at my discretion.

ACADEMIC DISHONESTY. I take violations of the University's academic dishonesty policy—reprinted below—very seriously. Please review the policy and let me know if you have any questions.

GRADING SCALE. The course will follow a standard grading scale:

93-100	A	80-82	B-
90-92	A-	77-79	C+
87-89	B+	70-76	C
83-86	B	60-69	D

A NOTE ON GRADES. I do not *give* grades. You *earn* grades. It is essential that you are proactive regarding your performance in this course; *do not wait* until grades are posted and then ask how your grade could be improved. At that point, barring a mathematical error on my part, it cannot be. If, at any point, you are unsure of your current standing in the course, please come to my office hours.

ACADEMIC DISHONESTY. The Department of Political Science, along with the College of the Liberal Arts and the University, takes violations of academic dishonesty seriously. Academic integrity is the pursuit of scholarly activity in an open, honest and responsible manner. Academic integrity is a basic guiding principle for all academic activity at The Pennsylvania State University, and all members of the University community are expected to act in accordance with this principle. Consistent with this expectation, the University's Code of Conduct states that all students should act with personal integrity, respect other students' dignity, rights and property, and help create and maintain an environment in which all can succeed through the fruits of their efforts.

Academic integrity includes a commitment by all members of the University community not to engage in or tolerate acts of falsification, misrepresentation or deception. Such acts of dishonesty violate the fundamental ethical principles of the University community and compromise the worth of work completed by others.

Penn State defines academic integrity as "the pursuit of scholarly activity in an open, honest and responsible manner" (Senate Policy 49-20). Dishonesty of any kind will not be tolerated in this course. Dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarizing, fabricating information or citations, facilitating acts of academic dishonesty by others, having unauthorized possession of examinations, submitting work of another person or work previously used without permission from the instructor, or tampering with the academic work of other students. All course work by students is to be done on an individual basis unless an instructor clearly states that an alternative is acceptable. Any reference materials used in the preparation of any assignment must be explicitly cited. Students uncertain about proper citation are responsible for checking with their instructor. In an examination setting, unless the instructor gives explicit prior instructions to the contrary, whether the examination is in-class or take-home, violations of academic integrity shall consist but are not limited to any attempt to receive

assistance from written or printed aids, or from any person or papers or electronic devices, or of any attempt to give assistance, whether the one so doing has completed his or her own work or not.

Lying to the instructor or purposely misleading any Penn State administrator shall also constitute a violation of academic integrity. In cases of any violation of academic integrity it is the policy of the Department of Political Science to follow procedures established by the College of the Liberal Arts. Students facing allegations of academic misconduct should not drop the course; those who do will be added to the course again and will be expected to complete course work and meet course deadlines. If the allegations are dismissed, then the drop will be permitted. Students found responsible for academic misconduct often receive academic sanctions, which can be severe, and put themselves at risk for disciplinary sanctions assigned by the University's Office of Student Conduct (see Senate Policy G-9). Students with questions about academic integrity should visit https://la.psu.edu/current-students/undergraduate-students/education/academic-integrity.

NOTE TO STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES. Penn State welcomes students with disabilities, whether permanent or temporary, visible or hidden, into the university's educational programs. The Office for Student Disability Resources (SDR) offers support specifically tailored to the needs of graduate students. The Student Disability Resources (SDR) website provides information and contact information for every Penn State campus.

To be considered for reasonable accommodations, you must contact the appropriate disability services office at the campus where you are officially enrolled, participate in an intake interview, and provide documentation: see documentation guidelines here. If the submitted documentation supports your request for reasonable accommodations, your campus disability services office will provide you with an accommodation letter or help you discuss reasonable accommodations with your instructor and/or graduate program chair. Please share this accommodation letter with your course instructors and discuss the accommodations with them as early as possible; this process is required for each semester for which you request accommodations.

An overview of disability resources specific to graduate students can be found here: https://equity.psu.edu/offices/student-disability-resources/graduate-students-with-disabilities.

COUNSELING AND PSYCHOLOGICAL SERVICES. Many students at Penn State face personal challenges or have psychological needs that may interfere with interfere with their academic progress, social development, or emotional wellbeing. The university offers a variety of confidential services to help you through difficult times, including individual and group counseling, crisis intervention, consultations, online chats, and mental health screenings. These services are provided by staff who welcome all students and embrace a philosophy respectful of clients' cultural and religious backgrounds, and sensitive to differences in race, ability, gender identity and sexual orientation.

Counseling and Psychological Services at University Park (CAPS): 814-863-0395
Penn State Crisis Line (24 hours/7 days/week): 877-229-6400
Crisis Text Line (24 hours/7 days/week): Text LIONS to 741741

EDUCATIONAL EQUITY AND REPORTING BIAS INCIDENTS. State takes great pride to foster a diverse and inclusive environment for students, faculty, and staff. Acts of intolerance, discrimination, or harassment due to age, ancestry, color, disability, gender, gender identity, national origin, race, religious belief, sexual

orientation, or veteran status are not tolerated and can be reported through Educational Equity via the Report Bias webpage. You may also contact one of the following offices:

University Police Services, University Park: 814-863-1111
Multicultural Resource Center, Diversity Advocate for Students: 814-865-1773
Office of the Vice Provost for Educational Equity: 814-865-5906
Office of the Vice President for Student Affairs: 814-865-0909
Affirmative Action Office: 814-863-0471

Call 911 in cases where physical injury has occurred or is imminent.

STUDENT CARE & ADVOCACY OFFICE. College presents a number of challenges for students, and Penn State maintains an office of Student Care & Advocacy that can point you in the right direction if you are facing any of the following issues:

- Death of an immediate family member
- Family crisis
- Mental health concern
- Self-injurious behavior
- Food insecurity
- Housing insecurity
- Medical emergency and/or hospitalization
- Local natural disaster
- Academic distress
- Unexpected events or challenges

If you have questions, concerns, or need more information, please do not hesitate to contact that office by phone at 814-863-2020 or by email at StudentCare@psu.edu. They encourage you to call or e-mail ahead.

EXTENDED ABSENCES. During your enrollment at Penn State, unforeseen challenges may arise. If you ever need to miss an extended amount of class in such a circumstance, please notify your professor so you can determine the best course of action to make up missed work. If your situation rises to a level of difficulty you cannot manage on your own with faculty support, reach out to the Student Care & Advocacy office by phone at (814-863-2020) or email them at StudentCare@psu.edu. Office hours are Monday-Friday, 8 a.m. to 5 p.m.

USE OF ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE. You are responsible for the material you produce for this class. I understand that many of you may use large language models or other forms of artificial intelligence as you are working on assignments. My evaluation of your written work is based on your ability to explain your ideas both in writing and orally in class. If I have questions about something you have written or submitted for class, I may ask you to explain it to me. Failure to be able to do so well, whether it is because you have used AI or not, is grounds for a lower grade.

SCHEDULE

Below, you'll find a list of all class meetings, the topic we'll discuss, and the reading assignment. You should complete the reading assignment before you come to class and bring any questions that you have with you to our class meetings. If deviations from this schedule are necessary, they will be announced in class.

Part I: People and Groups in the States

Week 1: Introduction (8/24)

- Nelson, Michael J. "How to Read Journal Articles Like a Professor."
- Berkman, Michael B., Morrgan T. Herlihy, and Michael J. Nelson. 2026. "*SPPQ* and the Development of the State Politics Subfield." *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 16(1): 1-22.
- Key, V.O. 1949. *Southern Politics in State and Nation*. New York: Alfred A. Knopf. Chapters 1, 14, 18-20, 24, plus one of the state chapters:
    - Georgia: Ritwik, Sam
    - South Carolina: Connor, Ozzy
    - Virginia: Madison, Maya
    - North Carolina: Yipeng, Spencer
    - Alabama: Christine, Zach

Week 2: Parties in the States (8/31)

- Holbrook, Thomas M., and Emily Van Dunk. 1993. "Electoral Competition in the American States." *American Political Science Review*. 87:955-962.
- Masket, Seth. 2007. "It Takes an Outsider: Extralegislative Organization and Partisanship in the California Assembly, 1849-2006." *American Journal of Political Science* 51(3): 482-497.
- Grumbach, Jacob M. 2023. "Laboratories of Democratic Backsliding." *American Political Science Review* 117(3): 967-984.
- Dynes, Adam M. and John B. Holbein. 2020. "Noisy Retrospection: The Effect of Party Control on Policy Outcomes." *American Political Science Review* 114(1): 237-257.
- Gamm, Gerald and Thad Kousser. 2021. "Life, Literacy, and the Pursuit of Prosperity: Party Competition and Policy Outcomes in 50 States." *American Political Science Review* 115(4): 1442-1463.

Week 3: Labor Day, No Class (9/7)

Week 4: Electoral Institutions (9/14)

- Anzia, Sarah F. 2011. "Election Timing and the Electoral Influence of Interest Groups." *Journal of Politics* 73(2): 412-427.
- Fraga, Bernard L. and Michael G. Miller. 2022. "Who Do Voter ID Laws Keep From Voting?" *Journal of Politics* 84(2): 1091-1105.
- Ladam, Christina, Jeffrey J. Harden, and Jason H. Windett. 2018. "Prominent Role Models: High-Profile Female Politicians and the Emergence of Women as Candidates for Public Office." *American Journal of Political Science* 62(2): 369-381.
- Butler, Daniel M., Adam M. Dynes, and Michelle Torres. 2026. "Nonpartisan Ballots and the Partisanship of Who Serves in Office." *Journal of Politics* Forthcoming.
- Conevska, Aleksandra, et al. 2026. "How Partisan are U.S. Local Elections? Evidence from 2020 Cast Vote Records." *American Political Science Review* 120(2): 564-581.

Week 5: No Class (9/21) [MJN in Japan. Work on finding a topic for the final project]

Week 6: Electoral Accountability (Board of Visitors Meeting) (9/28)
We will reschedule this class session due to the Political Science Department's alumni Board of Visitors meeting. Also please meet with me this week to discuss your final project (Checkpoint #1).

- Brunett, Craig M. and Vladimir Kogan. 2017. "The Politics of Potholes: Service Quality and Retrospective Voting in Local Elections." *Journal of Politics* 79(1): 302-314.
- Rogers, Steven. 2017. "Electoral Accountability for State Legislative Roll-Calls and Ideological Representation." *American Political Science Review* 111(3): 555-571.
- de Benedictis-Kessner, Justin and Christopher Warshaw. 2020. "Accountability for the Local Economy at All Levels of Government in United States Elections." *American Political Science Review* 114: 660-676.
- Handan-Nader, Cassandra, Andrew C.W. Myers, and Andrew B. Hall. 2026. "Polarization and State Legislative Elections." *American Journal of Political Science* 70(2): 453-470.

Week 7: Policy Responsiveness to Public Opinion (10/5)

- Erikson, Robert, Gerald Wright, and John McIver. 1993. *Statehouse Democracy: Public Opinion and Policy in the American States*. Cambridge University Press. Chapters 4-6.
- Lax, Jeffrey R. and Justin H. Phillips 2012. "The Democratic Deficit in the States." *American Journal of Political Science* 56(1): 148-166.
- Broockman, Daniel and Christopher Skovron. 2018. "Bias in Perceptions of Public Opinion among Political Elites." *American Political Science Review* 112(3): 542-563.
- Caughey, Devin and Christopher Warshaw. 2018. "Policy Preferences and Policy Change: Dynamic Responsiveness in the American States, 1936-2014." *American Political Science Review*. 112(2): 249-266.
- Olson, Michael P. 2025. "'Restoration' and Representation: Legislative Consequences of Black Disfranchisement in the American South, 1879-1916. *American Journal of Political Science* 69(2): 287-405.

Part II: Institutions in the States

Week 8: Parties in Legislatures (10/12)
[Checkpoint #2 due. Midterm Exam Handed Out]

- Wright and Schaffner. 2002. "The Influence of Party: Evidence from the State Legislatures" *American Political Science Review* 96:367-79
- Boris Shor and Nolan McCarty. 2022. "Two Decades of Polarization in American State Legislatures." *Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy* 3(3-4): 343-370.
- Butler, Daniel, Zoe Nemerever, and Steven Rogers. 2026. "Legislative Control and Partisan Disparities in Dyadic Representation." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 51(1): e70050.
- Provins, Tessa, Nathan W. Monroe, and David Fortnato. 2022. "Allocating Costly Influence in Legislatures." *Journal of Politics* 84(3): 1697-1713.
- Christian Fong and Michael Kistner. 2026. "Ambition and Conflict in State Legislatures" *Journal of Politics* Forthcoming.

Week 9: Legislative Professionalism and Term Limits (10/19)
[Midterm Exam Due]

- Squire, Peverill. 1992. "The Theory of Legislative Institutionalization and the California Assembly," *Journal of Politics* 54: 1026-1054.
    - Squire, Peverill. 2024. "A Squire Index Update: Stability and Change in Legislative Professionalism, 1979-2021." *State Politics and Policy Quarterly* 7(2): 211-27.
    - Brown, Adam R. and Ellie M. Mitchell. 2025. "Comparing Three Measures of Legislative Professionalism." *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 25(1): 119-131.
- Michael P. Olson and Jon C. Rogowski. 2020. "Legislative Term Limits and Polarization." *Journal of Politics* 82(2): 572-586.
- Hall, Andrew B. and Alexander Fouirnaies. 2021. "How Do Electoral Incentives Affect Legislator Behavior? Evidence from U.S. State Legislatures." *American Political Science Review* 116(2) 662-676.
- Cook, Scott J. and David Fortunato. 2022. "The Politics of Police Data: State Legislative Capacity and the Transparency of State and Substate Agencies." *American Political Science Review* 117(1): 280-295.
- Bucchianeri, Peter, Craig Volden, and Alan E. Wiseman. 2025. "Legislative Effectiveness in the American States." 119(1): 21-29.

Week 10: Governors (10/26)

- Barrilleaux, Charles and Michael Berkman. 2003. "Do Governors Matter? Budgeting Rules and the Politics of State Policy Making," *Political Research Quarterly* 56: 409-17.
- Brown, Adam. 2010. "Are Governors Responsible for the State Economy? Partisanship, Blame, and Divided Federalism." *Journal of Politics* 72(3): 605-15.
- Robert J. McGrath, Jon C. Rogowski, and Josh M. Ryan. 2018. "Veto Override Requirements and Executive Success." *Political Science Research and Methods* 6:153–79.
- Noble, Benjamin S. and Daniel M. Butler. 2026. "Are Voters' Preferences Being Ignored in Governor's Agendas?" *Political Research Quarterly* 79(2): 587-604.

Week 11: Interbranch Relations and Direct Democracy (11/2)
[Checkpoint #3 Due]

- Gerber, Elisabeth R. 1996. "Legislative Response to the Threat of Popular Initiatives." *American Journal of Political Science.* 40:99-128.
- Boehmke, Frederick J., Tracy L. Osborn and Emily U. Schilling. 2015. "Pivotal Politics and Initiative Use in the American States." *Political Research Quarterly* 68 (4): 665-677.
- Kousser, Thad and Justin H. Phillips. 2009. "Who Blinks First? Legislative Patience and Bargaining with Governors." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 34(1): 55-86.
- Birkhead, Nathaniel A., Jeffrey J. Harden, and Jason H. Windett. 2026. "Executive-Legislative Policymaking Under Crisis." *Journal of Politics* 88(2): 882-887.
- Vakilifathi, Mona. 2020. "Strategic Delegation? How Legislative Political Elites Respond to Electoral Uncertainty." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 46(2): 559-583.

Week 12: Judicial Elections and the Public (11/9)

- Hall, Melinda Gann and Chris W. Bonneau. 2006. "Does Quality Matter? Challengers in State Supreme Court Elections." *American Journal of Political Science* 50: 20-33.
- Gibson, James L. 2008. "Challenges to the Impartiality of State Supreme Courts: Legitimacy Theory and 'New-Style' Judicial Campaigns." *American Political Science Review* 102: 59-75.
- Nelson, Michael J. and James L. Gibson. 2026. "Institutional Structures and Judicial Legitimacy." *Political Research Quarterly* 79(1): 248-262.
- Canes-Wrone, Brandice, Tom S. Clark, and Jason P. Kelly. 2014. "Judicial Selection and Death Penalty Decisions." *American Political Science Review* 108:23-39.
- Kastellec, Jonathan P. 2018. "How Courts Structure State-Level Representation." *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 18(1): 27-60.

Part III: Making Policies in the States

Week 13: Policy Innovation, Competition, and Diffusion (11/16)
[Circulate Draft for Checkpoint 4]

- SKIM: Walker, Jack L. 1969. "The Diffusion of Innovations among the American States." *American Political Science Review* 63: 880-899.
- SKIM: Berry, Frances Stokes, and William D. Berry. 1990. "State Lottery Adoptions as Policy Innovations: An Event History Analysis." *American Political Science Review*. 84:395-416.
- Shipan, Charles R. and Craig Volden. 2008. "The Mechanisms of Policy Diffusion." *American Journal of Political Science* 52(4): 840-857.
- Desmarais, Bruce; Jeffrey J. Harden and Frederick J. Boehmke. 2015. "Persistent Policy Pathways: Inferring Policy Diffusion Networks in the American States." *American Political Science Review* 109(2): 392-406.
- Butler, Daniel M., Craig Volden, Adam Dynes, and Boris Shor. 2017. "Ideology, Learning and Policy Diffusion: Experimental Evidence." *American Journal of Political Science* 61(1): 37-49.
- Kroeger, Mary, Timothy Callaghan and Andrew Karch. "Model Bills, State Imitation, and the Political Safeguards of Federalism." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 47(4): 855-884..

Week 14: Federalism (11/30)
[Checkpoint 4 Due]

- Bromley-Trujillo, Rebecca and Michael Dichio. 2025. "The State of American Federalism 2024-2025: Resisting and Reinforcing the Rise of the Transactional Presidency." *Publius: The Journal of Federalism* 55(3): 415-444.
- Grumbach, Jacob M. and Jamila Michener. 2022. "American Federalism, Political Inequality, and Democratic Erosion." *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 699(1): 143-155.
- Weissert, Carol. S. and D. Scheller. 2008. "Learning from the States? Federalism and National Health Policy." *Public Administration Review* 68: S162-S174
- Kelly, Nathan J. and Christopher Witko. 2012. "Federalism and American Inequality." *Journal of Politics* 74(2): 414-426.
- Volden, Craig. 2002. "The Politics of Competitive Federalism: A Race to the Bottom in Welfare Benefits?" *Journal of Politics* 46(2): 352-363.

Week 15: Nationalization (12/7)

- Hopkins, Dan. 2018. *The Increasingly United States: How and Why American Political Behavior Nationalized*. University of Chicago Press. Chapters 1, 2, and 6.
- Moskowitz, Daniel J. 2021. "Local News, Information, and the Nationalization of U.S. Elections." *American Political Science Review* 115: 114-129.
- Das, Sanmay, Betsy Sinclair, Steven W. Webster and Hao Yan. 2022. "All (Mayoral) Politics is Local?" *Journal of Politics* 84: 1021-1034.
- Hopkins, Daniel J., Eric Schickler, and David Azizi. 2021. "From Many Divides, One? The Polarization and Nationalization of American State Party Platforms, 1918-2017." *Studies in American Political Development* 36: 1-20.
- Halliday, Derek E. and Aaron F. Rudkin. 2026. "DC On My Mind: Voter Evaluations of Nationalized Policy Positions in State and Local Elections." *Journal of Politics* Forthcoming.

Finals Week

Your paper is due at 5pm on 12/14.

You should also know about:

Measuring Subnational Public Opinion (10/5)

- Erikson, Robert, Gerald Wright, and John McIver. 1993. *Statehouse Democracy: Public Opinion and Policy in the American States*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press. Chapters 1-3.
- Berry, William D., Evan J. Ringquist, Richard C. Fording, and Russell L. Hanson. 1998. "Measuring Citizen and Government Ideology in the American Sates." *American Journal of Political Science*. 42:337-348.
- Lax, Jeffrey R., and Justin H. Phillips. 2009. "How Should We Estimate Public Opinion in the States?" *American Journal of Political Science* 53(1): 107-21.
- Enns, Peter and Julianna Koch. 2013. "Public Opinion in the U.S. States: 1656 to 2010." *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 13(3): 349-372.
- Smith, Candis Watts, Rebecca J. Kreitzer, and Feiya Suo. 2019. "The Dynamics of Racial Resentment in the US States, 1988-2016." *Perspectives on Politics*.